realised there was no choice. My boss was counting on this operation.'

To explore the major turning point in the relationship between India and Iran, Vipul sifted through several records that could shed light on how the USA played a key role in determining the relationship between the two countries that had always been perceived as non-aligned. He came across a conversation that took place on 3 October 1973 between the then foreign minister, Swaran Singh, and the then US secretary of state, Henry Kissinger at the state department office just hours before the two leaders sat down to lunch. Here is an excerpt:

Henry Kissinger: Our only interest is to see success in your efforts. We do not support one side or the other. We have some concern only about Afghanistan. We have told Pakistan and Iran not to interfere in the internal affairs of

Afghanistan unless Afghanistan tries to subvert their internal system.

Swaran Singh: This matter came up when I went to Iran and spoke to the Shahenshah.

Henry Kissinger: The Shah mentioned to me about your visit.

Swaran Singh: I asked him plainly, is it your position that you will always side with Pakistan against India, whatever the merits of the question are? And he said that it was not a blanket commitment to Pakistan. He made two points-(l) if Pakistan was aggressed upon, he would support Pakistan, but he did not think it was India's policy to commit aggression against Pakistan (2) if there was a danger of disintegration of Pakistan, particularly in Balochistan, he would support Pakistan in